

value in exchange for a present liquidation of his structured settlement.

Ruling

1. The Court orders the appearance of Erik Hornbuckle, either in person or remotely, at the hearing in order for the court to address the above concerns with him.
2. The Court will issue a ruling at the hearing.
3. Counsel for LVNV is ordered to appear. Appearance can be done remotely.

Discovery Law & Motion

23. 9:01 AM CASE NUMBER: C24-01877

CASE NAME: ZACHARY MINOR VS. CRAIG HOWARD

***HEARING ON MOTION FOR DISCOVERY COMPEL FURTHER RESPONSES TO PLAINTIFF'S REQUESTS FOR ADMISSION, SET TWO**

FILED BY: MINOR, ZACHARY

TENTATIVE RULING:

Summary

This ruling addresses the following discovery motions, listed on Lines 23 and 24 of the Court's calendar:

1. Plaintiffs Zachary and Angela Minor's Motion to Compel Further Responses to Plaintiff's Request for Admissions, Set Two, filed April 14, 2026; and
2. Plaintiffs Zachary and Angela Minor's Motion to Compel Further Responses to Plaintiff's Special Interrogatories, Set Two, filed April 14, 2026.

The Court has reviewed the motions and the accompanying "meet and confer" correspondence exchanged between Plaintiff Zachary Minor and counsel for Defendant Craig Howard. The Court notes that no opposition has been filed by Defendant.

However, the Court's records contain no Proof of Service demonstrating that Plaintiffs served either motion upon Defendant Craig Howard or his counsel of record, Gordon Rees.

Both motions are **dismissed** without prejudice.

Analysis

The Court is aware that Plaintiffs are proceeding without an attorney in their lawsuit. However, a self-represented party "is to be treated like any other party and is entitled to the same, but no greater consideration than other litigants and attorneys." *Williams v. Pacific Mutual Life Ins. Co.* (1986) 186 Cal.App.3d 941, 944. Thus, as is the case with attorneys, self-represented litigants must follow correct rules of procedure. *Nwosu v. Uba* (2004) 122 Cal.App.4th 1229, 1246-1247; see also *Rappleyea v. Campbell* (1994) 8 Cal.4th 975, 984-85 ("mere self-representation is not a ground for exceptionally

lenient treatment. Except when a particular rule provides otherwise, the rules of civil procedure must apply equally to parties represented by counsel and those who forgo attorney representation."); see also *Leslie v. Board of Medical Quality Assurance* (1991) 234 Cal.App.3d 117, 121 (self-represented parties are held to "the same 'restrictive procedural rules as an attorney'"). Self-represented litigants are not entitled to special treatment and are required to follow the procedural rules that govern civil litigation. *McComber v. Wells* (1999) 72 Cal.App.4th 512, 522-523.

Nevertheless, "[t]rial judges must acknowledge that in *propria persona* litigants often do not have an attorney's level of knowledge about the legal system and are more prone to misunderstanding the court's requirements.' [Citation.] When one party has counsel and the other does not, the trial court 'should monitor to ensure the in *propria persona* litigant is not inadvertently misled, either by the represented party or by the court. ... [S]pecial care should be used to make sure that verbal instructions given in court and written notices are clear and understandable by a layperson. This is the essence of equal and fair treatment, and it is not only important to serve the ends of justice, but to maintain public confidence in the judicial system.'" *Petrosyan v. Prince Corp.* (2013) 223 Cal.App.4th 587, 594.

Applied here, there is no evidence that Plaintiffs were misled by the Court or Defendants. Indeed, the Court's prior rulings and orders to comply with her discovery obligations in previous motions set forth compliance dates.

The record of proceedings reflect that Plaintiff did not serve either motion on Defendant through his counsel of record. As such, the Court is without jurisdiction to hear either motion.

Ruling

Both motions are **DISMISSED WITHOUT PREJUDICE** for failure to effectuate service as required by law.

24. 9:01 AM CASE NUMBER: C24-01877
CASE NAME: ZACHARY MINOR VS. CRAIG HOWARD
***HEARING ON MOTION FOR DISCOVERY COMPEL FURTHER RESPONSES TO PLAINTIFFS' SPECIAL INTERROGATORIES, SET TWO**
FILED BY: MINOR, ZACHARY

TENTATIVE RULING:

See Line 23.

Law & Motion
Add On